Lorenz Gschwent

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Research interests

Applied Microeconomics, Economics of Innovation

References

Tobias Seidel	Martin Karlsson	Philip Jung
University of Duisburg-Essen	University of Duisburg-Essen	TU Dortmund University
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Education

PhD in Economics — 2022 - 2027 (expected)
University of Duisburg-Essen,
RTG Regional Disparities and Economic Policy
Supervisor: Tobias Seidel

Master of Science in Economics — 2019 - 2021
University of Vienna, Academic track

Erasmus Semester — September 2020 - January 2021
Aix-Marseille School of Economics,
"Econometrics, Big Data, Statistics" track

Bachelor of Science in Economics — 2015 - 2019
University of Vienna

Bakkalaureat of Philosophy in Communication Science — 2014 - 2018
University of Vienna

Current projects

"Granting Intellectual Property Rights: Invention Quality and the Scope of Protection". Job Market Paper.

Abstract: A patent office judges an invention's quality and the scope of the legal protection requested. I measure both from the text of 5.4 million US patent applications and show that patent examination decides how much protection inventions receive far more than which inventions receive protection. Using variation in applications' assignment to examiners, I find that among granted patents, the average alternative examiner would have refused about 8.6% of the broadest requests but only 5.9% of the narrowest. Studies that use the examiner assignment to estimate what a patent does therefore describe applications with

broad requests far more than applications of low quality. In a model where applicants choose how much to request, a stricter office narrows patents mostly because applicants ask for less. Under stricter examination, as reform proposals call for, the composition of inventions receiving patents changes far less than under an equally strict test of invention quality.

"Censorship in Democracy". With Marcel Caesmann and Matteo Grigoletto.
Working Paper. Current Draft.
Abstract: Democracies increasingly use censorship to counter foreign propaganda, yet evidence on its consequences remains scarce. We exploit the European Union's 2022 ban on Russia Today (RT) and Sputnik as a natural experiment, using a triple-difference design that compares users connected to the banned outlets against unconnected users in EU and non-EU countries. We analyze a daily panel of 677,780 tweets from 146,633 Twitter users in seven European countries. Pro-Russia output declines by 21.7% among connected EU users; in a difference-in-differences comparison with non-EU users, total pro-Russia output among EU users falls by 13.6%. Alternative suppliers do not fill the gap: neither their pro-Russia output nor the engagement they receive rises after the ban. Consistent with an agenda-setting role of the banned outlets, the share of EU users' tweets covering the outlets' daily top-five topics decreases by 17%. A survey experiment offers suggestive evidence that such censorship can come at a cost to the very norms it is meant to defend.

Publications

"The Rise of Health Economics: Transforming the Landscape of Economic Research". With Björn Hammarfelt, Martin Karlsson, and Mathias Kifmann. Health Economics.
Abstract: This paper explores the evolving role of health economics within economic research and publishing over the past 30 years. Historically, largely a niche field, health economics has become increasingly prominent, with the share of health economics papers in top journals growing significantly. We aim to identify the factors behind this rise. Using a combination of bibliometric methods and natural language processing, we classify abstracts to define health economics. Adapting Kelly et al.'s (2021) method to evaluate the novelty, impact, and quality of academic papers, we demonstrate that the mainstreaming of health economics is driven by innovative, high-quality research, with two notable waves in quality ratings that highlights the emergence and impact of distinct subfields within the discipline. We find a strong positive correlation between citations and quality ratings, with health economics papers receiving fewer citations for their quality compared to other economics fields. Pandemic-related research received a high number of citations during 2020 and 2021; however, our findings indicate that this work was not systematically more novel or impactful than prior studies within the same subfield.

Presentations

2026: DRUID Academy, ZEW PRICE Seminar, ICSSI Boulder, Melbourne Institute

2025: 18th RGS Doctoral Conference, 2nd Duke Strategy PhD Conference, BSE Summer Forum (Economics of Science and Innovation), REGIS Summer School, EPIP Annual Conference, 8th RISE Workshop

2024: 7th Conference on the Political Economy of Democracy and Dictatorship, 17th RGS Doctoral Conference

2023: CINCH Research Agenda for Ukraine Workshop (online), 5th Monash-Warwick-Zurich Text-as-Data Workshop (online), NOeG (Annual Conference of the Austrian Economic Association), Digital Democracy Workshop DigDemLab, 17th CESifo Workshop on Political Economy, 2nd CESifo/ifo Junior Workshop on Big Data

Other publications (pre-PhD)

Digital Tasks and ICT Capital: Methodologies and Data (with Dario Guarascio, Stefan Jestl, Alireza Sabouniha, and Roman Stöllinger), wiiw Statistical Report No. 11, January 2023

Teaching

Teaching Assistant: Introductory Econometrics (BA; yearly, since summer term 2023), Introductory Microeconomics (BA; winter term 2026), Econometrics II (PhD; summer term 2026)

Supervision: Bachelor Seminar in Economics (since winter term 2022/'23), Master Seminar Applied Economic Research (summer term 2023), bachelor theses (5+ total)

Visiting

Melbourne Institute — September-November 2026

ZEW Mannheim — February-March 2026

Previous positions

Research Associate — October 2021 - August 2022
Wyss Academy for Nature at the University of Bern
Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant with Kai Gehring

Part-time Research Assistant — July 2021 - September 2021
The Vienna Institute for International Economic Studies (wiiw)

Awards

EPIP Young Scholar Award 2025 for "Granting Intellectual Property Rights: Invention Quality and the Scope of Protection" (presented as "Quality, Scope, and Leniency: Strategic application behavior at the US Patent Office")

SSES Young Economist Award 2025, NOeG Young Economist Award 2023 for "Censorship in Democracy"

Languages

German (native), English